

Left (top to bottom) Tenderloin, the tenderest of cuts, should virtually melt in the mouth; a gaucho prepares steaks on the *parrilla* in Argentina; barbecue in the famous port market in Montevideo

Below (top to bottom) Peter Luger's famous half-pound burger is made of porterhouse trimmings; *bistecca alla fiorentina*, a juicy steak on the bone from the Chianina cattle of Tuscany



Los Leños expensive

San Jose; +598 2900 2285

A big rack of meat always roasts over the open fire at the casually chic *parrilla* of Los Leños. Start with a succulent seafood appetizer and follow with the signature tenderloin steak – *filet de lomo* – accompanied by mustard or the more exotic Roquefort or black-pepper sauces.

NEW YORK, NY

New York City is famously home of the tasty and tender New York strip steak (also known as Kansas City strip steak or strip loin steak). Eat it like the locals: rare, doused in sauces, and accompanied by a serving of truffle mac (macaroni) and cheese.

Angelo & Maxie's Steakhouse inexpensive

Park Avenue South at 19th Street; www.angelo-maxies.com

This inexpensive steakhouse serves juicy, oversized steaks (and some great fish dishes) in a splendid 1930s, Art Deco-style setting. Start with a seafood appetizer and order some onion rings or green salad to accompany your steaks. It's a romantic dining spot and has a great bar too.

Ottomanelli New York Grill moderate

1325 Fifth Avenue; www.nycotto.com

Savvy New Yorkers make a beeline to this grill, which has been run by the Ottomanelli family since 1900. Its specialty is enormous sirloin-steak burgers. Strip and hanger steaks, marinated in red wine and fresh herbs, are grilled to perfection as well.

Peter Luger Steakhouse expensive

178 Broadway, Brooklyn; www.peterluger.com

Open for over a century, Peter Luger is the Big Apple's finest traditional steakhouse, with luxurious wooden decor and chandeliers. It's a family business, and uses only the best US short-loin beef. Try its signature porterhouse steak, which the waiter cuts into filet and sirloin at the table, and douses with a superb wasabi-flavored or Merlot-based sauce.

Quality Meats expensive

57 W. 58th St.; www.qualitymeatsnyc.com

This upmarket steakhouse sizzles with sex appeal. Its industrial-chic decor features light installations fashioned from butchers' hooks and walls made from wine bottles. Its New American cuisine produces classic steaks marinated in inventive sauces. The clientele is young and hip.

TEXAS

Texas rivals Argentina for the crown of world's greatest steak-eating destination. The giant southern state is synonymous with grasslands, thundering cattle herds, and the iconic American cowboy. Houston, its biggest city, serves some of its most memorable beef.

Taste of Texas Restaurant moderate

10505 Katy Freeway, Houston; www.tasteoftexas.com

Having the air of an old-style cowboy joint, "T-O-T," as it is known, is a down-to-earth Texas steakhouse that emphasizes old-fashioned friendliness and uncomplicated dining, led by huge, juicy beefsteaks. Order the prime rib and you will exit smiling.

Pappas Bros. Steakhouse expensive

5839 Westheimer Rd., Houston; www.pappasbros.com

One of Houston's finest steakhouses, Pappas Bros. has an aged interior of red leather and polished wood furnishings. Its dry-aged steaks – from the filet mignon and rib-eye to a huge porterhouse – draw meat-lovers from across Texas. Its seafood starters are wonderful.

FLORENCE, ITALY

Florentines harvest their beef from the white Chianina cattle that graze the grasses of Tuscany's valleys. In Florentine kitchens, the tender, flavorful Chianina meat becomes the *bistecca alla fiorentina* – the Renaissance city's emblematic beefsteak.

Trattoria Mario inexpensive

Via Rosina 2R; www.trattoria-mario.com

Family-run Mario's has served the workers of Florence's Central Market since 1953. Diners share tables and the day's menu is attached to the wall with tape. Florentine steaks arrive big, bloody, and with hunks of bread on the side.

Ristorante Paoli moderate

Via de' Tavolini 12R; www.casatrattoria.com

A vaulted 14th-century ceiling painted with frescoes from the 1800s overlooks the tables at Paoli. It's an inspired setting, and the cuisine here is equally divine. Order succulent Florentine steak.

Buca Lapi expensive

Via del Trebbio 1R; www.bucalapi.com

Opened in 1880 in the cellars of Palazzo Antinori, this is an intimate trattoria set beneath vaulted, frescoed ceilings. Its *bistecca chianina* (Florentine porterhouse) steak is masterful, cooked over a charcoal grill and sprinkled with olive oil.